

THE ALGORITHM

AI in Business • Where Intelligence Meets Industry

INTRODUCTION

AI is showing up in real business decisions — not just in tech companies, but in logistics warehouses, pharmaceutical labs, and customer service lines. For this newsletter, I looked at three industries where that shift is already visible: supply chain and logistics, healthcare and pharmaceuticals, and customer care.

What stood out to me is that none of these are flashy use cases. They're practical. They're solving problems that cost companies real money and real time. And they're already working.

At a Glance

Industry	Company / Product	AI Use Case	Business Impact
Logistics & Supply Chain	Lion + OpenAI Tools	Demand forecasting	Doubled accuracy; weeks → days
Healthcare & Pharma	Merck + Google Gemini	Agentic AI for R&D and ops	Faster drug workflows; \$1B deal
Customer Support	Salesforce / Home Depot AI	AI voice agents & chatbots	Shorter wait times, better routing

INDUSTRY 01 • LOGISTICS & SUPPLY CHAIN

Getting Forecasting Right — Before the Truck Even Leaves

Lion used OpenAI-powered tools to nearly double its demand forecasting accuracy, cutting response time from months down to days.

Supply chain teams make expensive guesses every day. Guess wrong on demand and you're either sitting on product you can't move or scrambling to fill orders you didn't see coming. Lion, a major beverage company, decided to stop guessing.

They started using an OpenAI-powered forecasting platform that pulls in variables like weather, seasonality, retail trends, and upcoming sporting events. The result: **forecasting accuracy nearly doubled**, and what used to take weeks or months to figure out now takes days.

That kind of speed matters because supply chain decisions have a ripple effect. If you know demand is spiking two weeks out instead of two months out, you can actually do something about it — adjust production, reroute inventory, get ahead of the gap. That's the difference between reacting and planning.

WHY IT MATTERS

Less wasted inventory. Fewer stockouts. Faster response when demand changes unexpectedly. The business case is straightforward — and the numbers back it up.

WHERE IT GOES NEXT

The logical next step is a live dashboard that suggests when to produce, ship, or hold based on real-time signals. Some companies are already building toward that — a system that doesn't just report what happened, but tells you what to do next.

INDUSTRY 02 • HEALTHCARE & PHARMACEUTICALS

Merck Is Betting \$1 Billion That AI Can Speed Up Drug Development

Their partnership with Google Cloud Gemini Enterprise is bringing AI into research, manufacturing, regulatory submissions, and more.

Drug development is slow by design. There are good reasons for that — patient safety, regulatory requirements, clinical evidence standards. But some of that slowness comes down to sheer administrative volume, and that's where AI is starting to make a dent.

Merck recently announced a major partnership with Google Cloud, centered on the Gemini Enterprise platform. The plan covers a wide range of operations: research, regulatory work, manufacturing, and commercial teams. **Merck has already used AI for clinical report automation and regulatory dossier preparation** — two tasks that are notoriously time-consuming and document-heavy.

The investment — up to \$1 billion over several years — signals that this isn't a pilot program. Merck is treating AI as a long-term operational tool, not a one-off experiment. And when you're dealing with the complexity of bringing a drug to market, anything that compresses the timeline without cutting corners on safety is genuinely valuable.

That said, healthcare AI still needs a lot of human review. These systems assist researchers and operations teams — they don't replace the judgment calls that affect patient outcomes.

WHY IT MATTERS

Faster workflows in pharma can mean faster access to treatments. That's not just a business win — it's a public health one. Reducing administrative drag also frees up researchers to focus on the work that actually requires them.

WHERE IT GOES NEXT

AI agents that work alongside scientists — helping with literature review, flagging inconsistencies in trial data, drafting regulatory language — are a realistic near-term outcome. The infrastructure for it is being built right now.

INDUSTRY 03 · CUSTOMER CARE & CONTACT CENTERS

No More "Press 1 for..." — AI Is Rewriting How Companies Answer the Phone

Salesforce and Home Depot are deploying AI that actually understands what customers are saying — and resolves issues without making them repeat themselves.

If you've ever gotten trapped in a phone menu trying to get a simple answer, you already understand the problem these companies are trying to fix.

Home Depot is replacing its entire phone menu system with an **AI voice agent that understands natural language**. Customers can explain what they need the way they'd explain it to a person — order status, product questions, store hours — and the AI handles it or routes them to the right person. The rollout is going across all U.S. stores within the year.

On the platform side, **Salesforce launched Agentforce Contact Center in March 2026** — a system that combines voice, digital channels, CRM data, and AI agents in one place. The idea is that human and AI agents work together, with AI handling the routine stuff so people can focus on the cases that actually need a human.

This works because a huge portion of customer service volume is repetitive — the same questions, the same requests, the same issues — and AI handles those reliably and fast. What changes for human agents is the quality of their work. Instead of answering the same question for the 40th time, they're handling the cases where empathy and judgment actually matter.

WHY IT MATTERS

Shorter wait times. Better routing. Lower costs. But also — and this gets overlooked — a better experience for the human agents who stay. Their jobs get more interesting when AI takes the repetitive load off.

WHERE IT GOES NEXT

AI as the first point of contact is probably inevitable for most large companies. What matters is building in clear escalation paths so customers aren't left talking to a bot when they genuinely need a person.

The Takeaway

What I found researching these three industries is that the AI applications getting traction aren't the most dramatic ones. They're the ones solving problems that businesses have had for a long time — forecasting errors, documentation bottlenecks, high-volume customer inquiries.

The common thread isn't the technology. It's the combination of AI doing what it does well — processing large amounts of data quickly and consistently — alongside human oversight for the decisions that actually matter. That balance is what makes these deployments work, and it's probably what separates the ones that last from the ones that don't.

AI is already part of everyday business operations. The question now isn't whether to use it — it's

how to use it well.

Sources

The Australian — Lion using OpenAI-powered tools for demand forecasting

Reuters — Merck and Google Cloud AI partnership

Salesforce — Agentforce Contact Center announcement, March 2026

New York Post — Home Depot AI voice agent rollout

AI Tool Use Note

Claude was used to help format and refine this newsletter. All research, sources, analysis, and conclusions are my own. I reviewed and edited every section to make sure it reflects my actual understanding of the material.